suggested by Beijing, would in fact be asymmetric since it was harder for India to move forward if and when necessary given terrain difficulties on its side. Delhi suggested instead that if China withdrew from Longju, India would then not invest it with its forces; further, in Ladakh, the Chinese should withdraw eastwards from the 1956 line while India would withdraw westwards of the line. The seemingly symmetric proposal for Ladakh also was asymmetric since the Chinese, having advanced further, would have to give up more territory. Zhou suggested the two prime ministers meet; Nehru thought this premature. Zhou then came back with roughly parallel arguments about asymmetry that India had made, and so it went: the two sides exchanging notes, letters, and memoranda for most of 1959.[70]

Despite the disagreements and the asymmetric offers on both sides, the Chinese restraint measures of January 1960 on target practice, food gathering, and military exercises in advanced areas did bring some calm, and border incidents reduced. After the 1960 summit, China began to stiffen its response, but even then, it aimed for restraint and negotiations. In response to India's Forward Policy in November 1961, Mao convened another meeting of his senior-most advisers. China decided to resume patrolling and road building, but with the proviso that only Mao could authorize the PLA to fire. As the encirclement and counter-encirclement of posts occurred in early 1962, Mao ordered the PLA to stand firm but not to fire the first shot. He called this posture 'armed coexistence'.[71] In July 1962, Zhou told Chinese Foreign Minister Chen Yi to meet Indian Defence Minister Krishna Menon during the Geneva conference on Laos. Menon blandly told Chen Yi there was no border problem, that China simply had to withdraw, and that Indian troops were on their own territory. When Chen suggested a joint communique, Menon said he would get back to him on it but never did (by the time Delhi replied, Chen had returned to China).[72] Also in July 1962, Chinese troops were told to hold positions, to warn off advancing Indian troops, and only to fire if Indian units got to within fifty metres and the Chinese felt endangered.[73] All in all, this suggests quite a different picture from the caricatures which portray China as being determined to attack and humiliate India after 1959.